project. Added to this was the sheer engineering challenge of building such a highway. In 1966, when the Karakoram Highway was being constructed, Pakistan initially favoured routing it through the Mintaka Pass. However, China, citing that Mintaka Pass would be more susceptible to air strikes, recommended the steeper and more secure Khunjerab Pass instead.[16] Ultimately, the new Karakoram Highway was built further south and west, passing over the Khunjerab Pass. The highway started from Kashgar in Sinkiang, ending at Hasan Abdal in Punjab, Pakistan.[17] This highway now provided the Chinese instant road access into the Indian subcontinent.

Was India's consolidation of its ground presence on the Siachen Glacier in 1984 really the pre-emption of Sino-Pak moves to grab hold of the glacier? After all, the Siachen Glacier rubs shoulders with the Ghent and peak 30 glaciers in the Shaksgam Valley.[18] By physically taking possession of the Siachen Glacier, India has negated the terms of the China and Pakistan border agreement of 1963. As quoted in the agreement, the boundary in the area near the Siachen Glacier runs along 'the top of the Broad Peak, the top of the Gasherbrum Mountain, Indira Col Pass and the top of the Teram Kangri Peak, and reaches its south-eastern extremity at the Karakoram Pass'.[19] Importantly, China signed this agreement with Pakistan as the party in control of the area, and Article VI of the agreement states that following a settlement of the Kashmir dispute, negotiations will be reopened if the sovereignty of the area is with India.